

Sales Training Debrief — Session 18

Information Is Currency. Inherit the Deal.

Sales training led by Corie Dawson, Director · Friday 29 May 2026 · Marketing Sweet

1. Information is the currency that wins pitches

The session opened with a live walkthrough of a deal in WA — a CNC mining client with a well-built website. The first instinct of most reps is to pitch. The first instinct of a strong rep is to gather. Information is not a polite formality before the close; it is the most valuable currency in the room. The more the rep gathers, the better the recommendation they can make — and the easier the close becomes.

"You guys are so keen to pitch, but you don't understand. The more information you gather will give you an idea of the purchasing habits of this individual."

Why information is the asymmetric advantage:

- Buying habits repeat. Knowing how a buyer made their last purchase predicts how they'll make the next one.
- Price tolerance reveals itself. The cost of the existing website hints at the budget for the next one.
- Networks unlock. Who built their current solution becomes a door to other prospects with the same profile.
- Confidence compounds. The rep walks into the close with conviction, not hope, because the recommendation matches what they've heard.

2. Statement questions — ask without asking

The mechanic for gathering information without triggering the buyer's defences. Direct questions ("How much did you pay?" / "Who built it?") feel like an interrogation. Buyers shut them down — "I can't remember" usually means "I don't want to tell you." The fix is to convert questions into statements that invite the buyer to confirm or correct.

How the conversion works:

DIRECT QUESTION (DEFENCE GOES UP)	STATEMENT FORM (DEFENCE STAYS DOWN)
"How much did you pay for the website?"	"You must have paid heaps — it looks fantastic."
"Who built your website?"	"It's a beautiful site. I'm just trying to understand the framework. Do you remember roughly the company?"
"What's your budget?"	"I'm not sure where you're sitting — some clients in your space go for this kind of setup at \$1,500..."
"Do you have other people you could refer?"	"You strike me as someone who knows a lot of people in this industry."
"Are you the decision-maker?"	"You sound like you're the one calling the shots"

DIRECT QUESTION (DEFENCE GOES UP)	STATEMENT FORM (DEFENCE STAYS DOWN)
	here."

"You can ask people questions without asking the questions — through the power of statement. Statements invite correction. Questions trigger defence."

3. Why "I can't remember" is rarely the truth

When a buyer claims not to remember something — who built their website, what they paid, who their last provider was — that's almost never an actual memory gap. It's a polite "none of your business." Reps who treat "I can't remember" as the end of the conversation miss the real signal: the question landed in the wrong way. Reframe and ask again — in statement form.

The reframe in practice:

- Acknowledge the buyer's autonomy. "No worries — I'm just trying to map the structure so I can give you a sharper recommendation."
- Give them a reason that serves them. "It helps me figure out how the site was built so I know how easy it'll be to rank."
- Soften the ask. "Just the rough location or name is enough — I can take it from there."
- Move on if they still resist. The fact that they're guarding the info is itself information.

4. Have a thesis before the call — and be ready to update it

The mental discipline that separates strong reps from average ones. Before picking up the phone, the rep should already have a working theory of what they're about to find. Industry, profile, likely price tolerance, likely objections, likely solution. The thesis is not a script — it's a hypothesis that the call either validates or breaks.

"I'm probably about 85% validated before I pitch anything. By the time I get to the recommendation, I know what's going to land — because I've spent the conversation validating my thesis, not improvising one."

How to build a working thesis:

1. Before the call — review industry, business size, public information. Form a working view of who they are and how they'll buy.
2. During the call — ask in statement form, listen for confirmations and breaks. Update the thesis as evidence comes in.
3. Mid-pitch — if a checkpoint contradicts the thesis, change tack. Don't push a recommendation that no longer fits.
4. End-of-call — the recommendation should feel inevitable to the buyer because it lines up with everything they've told you.

5. Active listening — repeat what they said back to them

The single most under-used skill in selling. The buyer says something. The rep absorbs it but doesn't reflect it back. The buyer doesn't know whether they were heard. The pitch that follows feels generic — because from the buyer's side, it is. The fix is to weave the buyer's own words back into the pitch three or four times explicitly.

"You're not just nodding and waiting for your turn to talk. When you repeat back what they told you — in their own words — they feel they can trust you. That's where the deal lives."

Active listening in pitch form:

- "One of the things you said earlier was that you want to expand — so the recommendation I'm about to make is built around that."
- "You mentioned the website hadn't been touched for a while, and you're getting work mostly through referrals — that's exactly the gap we're going to fix."
- "You told me your competitors are winning work that you're not even bidding on — let me show you what their keywords look like compared to yours."
- Aim for three explicit callbacks to the buyer's words per pitch. Less than that, and the buyer feels unheard. More than that, and it sounds rehearsed.

6. Inherit the close — don't chase it

The reframe at the heart of the session. New reps think the close is a moment of pressure at the end of the call. Strong reps know the close is inherited from the information stage. Ninety percent of the rep's effort goes into discovery, listening, validating, and recommending. Ten percent is the close — and by then, the buyer has already decided.

"You're looking for the answer on how to close the deal, and I keep saying to you — inherit the deal. The way you inherit is by doing the information stage right."

What inheriting looks like:

- The buyer hears their own concerns named back to them, with a solution attached.
- The recommendation is sized to evidence the rep has actually gathered, not pulled from thin air.
- The close itself sounds like "so it sounds like you're ready to go the next step" — not "so are you going to buy?"
- The buyer says yes because everything that came before said yes already.

7. The ask-for-help close

A specific closing move surfaced in the session. After the recommendation is on the table, the rep doesn't ask for the sale. They ask for help choosing. The phrasing inverts the power dynamic — the buyer goes from defending against a sales push to collaborating on a decision.

"Look — I've got some options, I'm not sure where to go from here. I know what I'd like to do, so I'll present that first. But let's work together on figuring out the right solution."

Why it works:

- "I'm not sure where to go from here" signals genuine humility — the buyer doesn't feel cornered.
- Presenting the recommended option first anchors the conversation, but framing it as "this is what I'd like to do" leaves room for the buyer to push back without losing face.
- Working together on the choice means the buyer ends up co-owning the decision — which makes the yes harder to walk back from.

8. The mistake-walk-back close

The most counterintuitive move in the session — and one of the most effective. After the rep has pitched a high option and the buyer has paused or pulled back, the rep voluntarily walks the recommendation down. Not by dropping the price — by reducing the scope, framing it as the rep's own mistake.

"I think I've stuffed up here. We don't need all these — let me take them out. That brings you down considerably. In hindsight, I should have just gone for this one."

Why this beats a direct discount:

- The price doesn't fall — the value adjusts. The rep keeps integrity intact.
- The buyer feels protected, not haggled. The rep is on their side.
- The buyer ends up at a recommendation they didn't expect — which feels like a personal win.
- Future upsells are easy: "In three months we'll review and add the extras back if the results justify them."

9. Read the buying pattern — and use it

Every buyer has a pattern. Most reveal it inside the first five minutes of the call. The rep's job is to identify the pattern and then either work with it (most cases) or surface it gently so the buyer can choose to break it (when the pattern is the obstacle).

PATTERN OBSERVED	HOW TO USE IT
Buyer is well-researched, knows the market	Lead with respect — "You've clearly done your homework." Skip basics. Jump to specifics.
Buyer has chosen cheap providers before	Acknowledge it explicitly: "You may have used cheaper providers before — and you can see what that's cost you."
Buyer announces decisions, never executes	Build in commitment mechanics — small deposit, booked next step, dated milestone.
Buyer opens with "I'm not buying today"	Mirror it: "I'm not selling today either — I just want

PATTERN OBSERVED	HOW TO USE IT
	to gather the right info." Defuses the defence.
Buyer pulls out fancy hardware, dresses sharp	Sell premium positioning: prestige, exclusivity, top-tier outcomes.

10. Action items this week

- Convert one question to a statement on every pitch this week. Notice the difference in what the buyer reveals.
- Before any meeting, write down your thesis. After the meeting, score how close it was to reality. The gap is where to focus your prep.
- Practise the active-listening callback — three explicit repeats of the buyer's words in every pitch.
- Try the "ask for help" close on one deal this week. Notice how the buyer's posture changes.
- On one stalled deal, try the mistake-walk-back. Reduce scope, frame it as your own error. Don't drop the price.
- On every call, identify the buying pattern within five minutes. Adapt the rest of the pitch accordingly.

THE ONE-LINER Gather first, recommend second, close inherited. Statements not questions. Listen back. Walk the value, not the price.